SOURCES SOUGHT/REQUEST FOR INFORMATION (RFI)
DEPARTMENT OF HOMELAND SECURITY/UNITED STATES SECRET SERVICE

Media Relations and Strategic Communications Training

This notice constitutes a Request for Information (RFI) pursuant to Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) Part 15.201 for the purpose of determining the capability of sources in the marketplace for a contemplated effort for Media Relations and Strategic Communications Training. This RFI is for procurement planning purposes only for eventual award and shall not be construed as a request for proposals/quotes, solicitation, or commitment on the part of the Government to issue any future solicitation or award. The Government will not reimburse any costs associated with the development and submission of materials in response to this request.

The contemplated effort would be a firm fixed price contract with a 12-month base period and 4 (12-month) option periods. The North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) code for this requirement is anticipated to be determined by the Government based on market research and the final acquisition strategy. The anticipated NAICS code for this requirement is 541990 – Professional Scientific, and Technical Services.

The United States Secret Service (USSS), Office of Training (TNG), is seeking information from qualified vendors capable of designing, developing, and delivering comprehensive Media Relations and Strategic Communications Training. This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only and is intended to identify qualified sources, innovative training approaches, and effective instructional methodologies that support the agency's media engagement requirements.

Responses will assist the Government in assessing industry capabilities and developing an acquisition strategy for future training requirements.

Purpose

The purpose of this RFI is to gather information from interested parties with expertise in media relations, public affairs, crisis communications, executive communications, and presentation skills development, particularly within federal law enforcement or similarly sensitive operational environments.

The Government seeks information regarding the availability of vendors capable of delivering tiered media relations training programs that prepare United States Secret Service personnel to confidently and effectively communicate with national, regional, and local media representatives in routine, high-profile, and crisis situations.

Description

The United States Secret Service requires a contractor capable of developing and delivering media relations training that equips personnel with practical skills for interacting with the media as official spokespersons and organizational representatives.

The training shall provide participants with a comprehensive understanding of:

- The modern media landscape.
- Government and law enforcement interactions with the media.
- Crisis communication strategies.
- Press conference management.
- Interview preparation and execution.
- Public safety messaging.
- Executive communications.
- Reputation management.
- Sound bite creation and message development.
- Strategic media engagement.
- Communications during National Special Security Events (NSSEs).

Training shall include a combination of classroom instruction, facilitated discussions, recorded media exercises, mock interviews, role-playing activities, scenario-based learning events, and individualized performance feedback.

RFI Objectives

The Government seeks information regarding industry capabilities to:

1. Develop and deliver a comprehensive media relations curriculum tailored to federal law enforcement environments.
2. Provide instruction based on current media practices and communication trends.
3. Conduct realistic, scenario-based training exercises reflecting Secret Service missions and operational environments.
4. Deliver executive-level media strategy instruction for senior leaders.
5. Enhance student effectiveness during interviews, public appearances, press conferences, and crisis communications events.
6. Improve spokesperson confidence and communication effectiveness during routine and high-pressure media engagements.
7. Provide measurable feedback and coaching to participants.

8. Incorporate practical exercises involving protective operations, cybercrime investigations, financial crimes, NSSEs, crisis events, and public safety messaging.
9. Ensure all training materials are compliant with Section 508 accessibility standards.

General Requirements

The contractor shall possess:

Subject Matter Expertise

- Extensive media relations experience.
- Demonstrated experience supporting federal law enforcement agencies or organizations operating within secure environments.
- Direct national media experience as:
    - A network-level correspondent,
    - News executive,
    - Senior communications executive, or
    - Crisis communications strategist.

Training Development Capabilities

The contractor shall develop:

- Programs of Instruction (POIs).
- Instructor lesson plans.
- Student guides and handout materials.
- Presentation materials.
- Role-playing exercises.
- Media scenarios and practical exercises.
- Course evaluations and feedback tools.
- Sample agendas and syllabi.

Training Delivery Capabilities

The contractor shall provide:

- Interactive instruction.
- Video-based learning products.
- Recorded mock interviews.
- Simulated media events.
- Press conference exercises.
- Individual coaching sessions.
- Breakout sessions and facilitated discussions.

Recording and Playback Capability

The contractor shall have the capability to:

- Record participant performances.

- Playback recorded interviews and exercises.
- Provide detailed critiques regarding:
    - Body language,
    - Messaging effectiveness,
    - Professional presence,
    - Interview techniques, and
    - Overall communication performance.

Course Structure Requirements

Media Relations 100-Level Course

- Audience: GS-13 personnel and above
- Class Size: Approximately 20 participants
- Duration: Three (3) days
- Frequency: Three (3) classes annually

Topics should include:

- Modern media landscape.
- Government communications.
- Media perceptions.
- Public safety messaging.
- NSSE communications.
- Interview techniques.
- Message development.
- Sound bites.
- Media engagement strategies.
- Managing sensitive information.

Media Relations 400-Level Executive Course

- Audience: GS-15 personnel and Senior Executives
- Class Size: Approximately 20 participants
- Duration: Three (3) days
- Frequency: Two (2) classes annually

Topics should include:

- Executive media strategy.
- Strategic communications.
- Reputation management.
- Recruitment messaging.
- Press conference leadership.
- Blocking and bridging techniques.
- Executive interview preparation.
- Advanced crisis communications.

National Threat Assessment Center (NTAC) Course

- Audience: NTAC employees, data scientists, and presenters
- Class Size: Approximately 20 participants
- Duration: Two (2) days

- Frequency: Two (2) classes annually

Topics should include:

- Communicating threat assessment findings.
- Delivering complex information to public audiences.
- School and law enforcement stakeholder engagement.
- Media interview techniques.
- Public speaking and presentations.
- Complex question and answer sessions.

Additional Training Topics

Vendors should address their ability to provide instruction in:

- Crisis communications.
- Tragedy response communications.
- Media scrutiny and organizational scandals.
- National and local media engagement.
- Aggressive reporting environments.
- Media ethics.
- Hidden-agenda interviewing techniques.
- Interview etiquette.
- Effective public messaging.
- Real-world demonstrations and exercises.

Acquisition Strategy

The Government intends to use responses to this RFI to assess industry capabilities, training methodologies, market capacity, and potential acquisition strategies.

Information received may be used to:

- Refine requirements.
- Identify commercially available solutions.
- Evaluate small business participation opportunities.
- Inform acquisition planning decisions.
- Develop future solicitation strategies.

Participation in this RFI is voluntary.

Response Content

Interested vendors are requested to provide the following information:

Company Information

- Company name.

- Business size and socioeconomic designation.
- DUNS/UEI number.
- CAGE Code.
- Corporate website.

Corporate Experience

- Description of relevant media relations training experience.
- Experience supporting federal law enforcement agencies.
- Experience supporting secure or classified operational environments.
- Examples of comparable contracts performed within the last five years.

Instructor Qualifications

- Resumes or biographies of proposed instructors.
- National media experience.
- Communications or journalism credentials.
- Law enforcement communications experience.

Training Methodology

- Description of course development approach.
- Sample instructional techniques.
- Scenario-based learning methods.
- Recording and playback capabilities.
- Participant assessment methods.

Course Development Samples

- Sample agenda.
- Sample lesson plan.
- Sample practical exercise.
- Sample student materials.
- Section 508 compliance approach.

Capability Statement

- Ability to support the course frequencies and class sizes identified in this RFI.
- Ability to customize training for Secret Service operational scenarios.
- Recommended best practices and emerging training trends.
- Estimate Amounts for this requirement.
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To support market research and acquisition planning, respondents are requested to provide nonbinding budgetary pricing information for the capabilities described in this notice. Pricing information may include estimated unit prices, labor categories and hourly rates, estimated total costs, commercial price lists, and the assumptions used to develop the estimate.

This request is for planning and market research purposes only. It is not a solicitation, request for proposal, request for quotation, or commitment by the Government to award a contract or reimburse respondents for any costs incurred in responding. Any pricing submitted will be used solely to inform the Government’s acquisition strategy and independent cost estimate.

Response Deadline & Submission Instructions

Interested parties shall submit responses electronically in PDF format.

Responses should not exceed ten (10) pages, exclude resumes.

The Government requests that responses must be sent to Willie Bethune at the following email address Willie.Bethune@usss.dhs.gov no later than 11/16/2026 4:00 pm Eastern Standard Time

Emails with attachments larger than 5 MB shall be broken down into multiple emails with no one attachment exceeding 5 MB. Proprietary information, if any, should be minimized and MUST BE CLEARLY MARKED. To aid the Government, please segregate proprietary information. Reference RFI Media Relations Training in the subject line of the email.